

Search engine rankings

According to research firm comScore, Google is the leader in the US market with 9.3 bn searches, followed by Yahoo! at 2.9 bn and Microsoft at 1.2 bn searches.

Google reigns

With the near apparent failure of three attempts – Cuil, Trooker and Exalead as Google alternatives, Page and Brin have reasons to cheer.

Feature

columns, the top one in the middle being the most important: this main display panel is called simply “Web” and tells you the number of results that are proposed by Facility experts. In other words, the results from Facility’s editorialised map of reliable sites.

The other widgets need not necessarily have been through the same filter, and may very well be the result of “normal” algorithmic search methods; they display other categories of results. The various categories include: *Last minute News* for any relevant items on news sites; *Social Network* – possibly relevant comments found on social networking sites; *Encyclopedia* – for hits in Wikipedia and similar sites; *Downloads* – these are typically PDF files; *Presentation* – any presentations, typically education or perhaps business oriented; *Video*, *Images* and *Audio*, all self-explanatory; and, *Disambiguation* – this is to display a variety of possibilities, such as in the search shown, on Leonardo da Vinci. You may well have been looking for information on the man himself, or a hotel that uses his name, or, of course, a certain best-selling book by Dan Brown. This widget displays such possible ambiguities.

An interesting point about the display is that the widgets give you, where possible, a

preview of the contents of the site. You do not have to click and open a new window or tab; the widget itself will expand and display the movie or whatever format the information might be in. You can, if you wish, also save the content. In this case you are saving the content itself for later viewing, not just saving a bookmark or link to the item. It is clear here where Facility’s background in publishing comes into play – this would be a suitable interface for any kind of multi-media based set of information.

The display is also customisable. The user can move the widgets around according to their relative importance. If you were doing a search on the use of the tobacco mosaic virus in genetics, then the News widget should hardly be at the top, but it certainly should be prominent if the search were on the US president, as in the example screenshot that is with this article.

You, as an end user, can add comments to search results, so that if another user makes the same search, they will be able to see your comments. How this will work, if at all, when large numbers of people use the system remains to be seen.

So, Facility does not only structure and organise the access to the information that is being searched, but it also organises

in a customisable way the display of the results. Potentially very useful is the fact that when you save a result – a video, PDF, etc. – the search request that produced that result is also saved; this way the context is retrievable. This should help avoid problems such as seeing a saved bookmark and not remembering the particular line of thought that led to it being saved. Every item that might result from a search can be managed in this way. The exception to this is anything that is copyright protected. This is detected automatically and the item cannot be saved.

The idea is to give users maximum flexibility to manage information. They do not have to keep leaving the search system to view information – it is brought into the Facility system instead. Of course, this has benefits for advertisers, who like it if the user is not always shooting off to some other site.

Over the next few months the final patents for this system will be settled, and the engine will start appearing in certain sites such as social network sites. The frequency with which Gianpiero Lotito mentioned such sites suggests that at least one must be high on his list of prospective clients. The general purpose public search engine will follow later. 

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